Dictionaries

H 1540

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A. Background

Although the free-floating form subdivision ***--Dictionaries*** is the standard subdivision for the concept of dictionaries, the following subdivisions are used to designate special categories of dictionaries or dictionary-like materials:

- --Concordances
- --Dictionaries, Juvenile
- --Directories
- --Encyclopedias
- --Encyclopedias, Juvenile
- --Gazetteers

- --Glossaries, vocabularies, etc.
- --Language--Glossaries, etc.
- --Nomenclature
- --Registers
- --Terminology
- --Terms and phrases

Except as noted in the procedures below, the provisions of this instruction sheet are generally applicable only to the subdivision ***–Dictionaries***, not to the special subdivisions listed above. Instructions on the use of some of these subdivisions appear in other instruction sheets. For guidelines on ***--Concordances***, see H 1670, sec. 3.f. For guidelines on ***--Directories*** and ***--Registers***, see H 1558. For guidelines on ***--Gazetteers***, see H 1630. For guidelines on ***--Glossaries, vocabularies, etc.***, ***--Terminology***, and ***--Terms and phrases***, see H 2184. For guidelines on dictionaries of acronyms, see H 1206.5. Use of the subdivision ***--Dictionaries and encyclopedias*** under names of places and ethnic groups was discontinued in 1990. Use of the subdivision ***--Dictionaries, indexes, etc.*** under names of individual persons and literary authors was discontinued in 1991.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Dictionaries***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

B. Recent revisions

2026-03: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Dictionaries: 1: a reference source in print or electronic form containing words usually alphabetically arranged along with information about their forms, pronunciations, functions, etymologies, meanings, and syntactic and idiomatic uses; 2: a reference book listing alphabetically terms or names important to a particular subject or activity along with discussion of their meanings and applications; 3: a reference book listing alphabetically the words of one language and showing their meanings or translations in another language[1]

[1] DICTIONARY Definition & Meaning - Merriam-Webster

D. Language dictionaries

Use the subdivision ***--Dictionaries*** as a form subdivision under names of languages for comprehensive, alphabetical lists of words in those languages, usually with definitions.

For incomplete lists of the words of a language which may or may not be alphabetically arranged, with or without definitions, use the subdivision ***--Glossaries, vocabularies, etc.***, under the name of the language. For lists of expressions, phrases, etc., found in a particular language use the subdivision ***--Terms and phrases*** under the name of the language.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading to bring out the topic. If the dictionary is general in nature, do not assign any subject headings to express a topic. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Dictionaries***.

D.1. Dictionaries in one language

Assign the heading ***[name of language]--Dictionaries***, for example, ***Spanish language--Dictionaries***.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading for the language or dialect, for example, ***Spanish language***. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Dictionaries***.

D.2. Dictionaries in two languages

If a dictionary gives the terms of one language in terms of another, assign the heading ***[name of first language]--Dictionaries--[name of second language]***, for example, ***German language--Dictionaries--English***. If the second language is also given in terms of the first, assign an additional heading with the languages reversed, for example, ***English language--Dictionaries--German***.

Omit the word language or dialect in formulating the subdivision following ***--Dictionaries***, for example, ***English language--Dictionaries--German*** [not ***English language--Dictionaries--German language***]; ***English language--Dictionaries--Cajun French*** [not ***English language--Dictionaries--Cajun French dialect***].

If the heading for the dialect that is represented by the topical subdivision following ***--Dictionaries*** is established in inverted order, formulate the subdivision by using the name of the dialect in natural-language order and omitting the word dialects, for example, ***English language--Dictionaries--French Creole*** [not ***English language--Dictionaries--Creole dialects, French*** or ***English language--Dictionaries--Creole, French***].

Do not assign a geographic subdivision after the subdivision ***–Dictionaries*** or ***--Dictionaries--[name of second language]***.

LC practice: Assign subject headings for the languages or dialects, for example, ***English language*** and ***Spanish language***. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Multilingual dictionaries***.

D.3. Polyglot dictionaries

If a dictionary gives the equivalent terms for one language in several other languages, assign the heading ***[name of language]--Dictionaries--Polyglot***. If each language is given in terms of the others, assign only the heading ***Dictionaries, Polyglot***.

LC practice: Assign the subject headings for the languages. If there are more than three languages of translation, assign the primary language and optionally assign subject headings for the other languages. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Multilingual dictionaries***.

D.4. Lexicography

For works about language dictionaries, use the free-floating topical subdivision ***--Lexicography*** under names of languages.

E. Subject dictionaries

Use the subdivision ***--Dictionaries*** as a form subdivision under subjects for works consisting of comprehensive, alphabetical lists of terms pertaining to those subjects, usually with definitions.

Use the subdivision ***--Dictionaries*** as a form subdivision under personal names for lists of terms related to an individual. For lists of terms used in the speech or writings of a person, use the subdivision ***--Language--Glossaries, etc.*** under the name of the person.

For incomplete lists of the terms associated with a particular subject, or for comprehensive lists of such terms that are not arranged alphabetically, use the form subdivision ***--Terminology*** under the subject. For guidelines on Terms and phrases, see H 2184.

For works consisting of explanatory articles arranged alphabetically or topically, use the form subdivision ***--Encyclopedias*** under the subject. For encyclopedias intended for children up through age 15 or 9th grade, use the subdivision ***--Encyclopedias, Juvenile*** under the subject.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading to bring out the topic. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Dictionaries***. Assign the LCDGT appropriate to the audience, e.g. LCDGT ***Children*** or ***Flight attendants***.

E.1. Dictionaries in one language

Assign the heading ***[topic]--[place, if appropriate]--Dictionaries--[name of language]*** except when the language is English. For English assign the heading ***[topic]--Dictionaries***, without indicating language.

LC practice: Assign a subject heading to bring out the topic. Assign a separate subject heading for the language, if other than English. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Dictionaries***.

Examples:

650 #0 $a Chemistry $v Dictionaries $x French.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Chemistry.
650 #0 $a French language.
655 ## $a Dictionaries. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a Science $v Dictionaries.
[not 650 #0 $a Science $v Dictionaries $x English.]

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Science.
655 ## $a Dictionaries. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a Law $z United States $v Dictionaries.
[not 650 #0 $a Law $z United States $v Dictionaries $x English.]

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Law $z United States.
655 ## $a Dictionaries. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a Theater $z France $v Dictionaries $x French.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Theater $z France.
650 #0 $a French language.
655 ## $a Dictionaries. $2 lcgft

E.2. Dictionaries in two languages

If a subject dictionary gives the terms of one language in terms of another language, assign two headings:

1. ***[topic]--[place, if appropriate—Dictionaries--[first language]***
2. ***[first language] --Dictionaries--[second language]***

If the second language is also given in terms of the first language, assign two additional headings:

3. ***[topic]--[place, if appropriate]--Dictionaries--[second language]***
4. ***[second language]--Dictionaries--[first language]***

Do not use the subdivision ***--English*** after ***[topic]--Dictionaries***.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision. See the LC practice above.

Examples:

Title: English-Persian dictionary of legal terms.

650 #0 $a Law $v Dictionaries.

650 #0 $a English language $v Dictionaries $x Persian.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Law.

650 #0 $a Persian language.

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

Title: Albanian-English military dictionary.

650 #0 $a Military art and science $v Dictionaries $x Albanian.

650 #0 $a Albanian language $v Dictionaries $x English.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Military art and science.

650 #0 $a Albanian language.

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

Title: Langenscheidts's dictionary of ecology : English-German/German-English.

650 #0 $a Ecology $v Dictionaries.

650 #0 $a English language $v Dictionaries $x German.

650 #0 $a Ecology $v Dictionaries $x German.

650 #0 $a German language $v Dictionaries $x English.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Ecology.

650 #0 $a German language.

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

E.3. Polyglot dictionaries

Several arrangements are possible for works in multiple languages. Assign headings as shown below, following the pattern that most closely corresponds to the situation in the work being cataloged. Do not use the subdivision ***--English*** after ***[topic]--Dictionaries***.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision. See the LC practice above.

Models:

One language into two languages:

650 #0 $a [topic] $v Dictionaries $x [first language].

650 #0 $a [first language] $v Dictionaries $x [second language].

650 #0 $a [first language] $v Dictionaries $x [third language].

LC practice:

650 #0 $a [topic].

650 #0 $a [first language].

650 #0 $a [second language].

650 #0 $a [third language].

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

One language into several languages:

650 #0 $a [topic] $v Dictionaries $x [first language].

650 #0 $a [first language] $v Dictionaries $x Polyglot.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a [topic].

650 #0 $a [first language].

650 #0 $a [other languages, up to three and optionally more].

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

Two languages into one language:

650 #0 $a [topic] $v Dictionaries $x [first language].

650 #0 $a [topic] $v Dictionaries $x [second language].

650 #0 $a [first language] $v Dictionaries $x [third language].

650 #0 $a [second language] $v Dictionaries $x [third language].

LC practice:

650 #0 $a [topic].

650 #0 $a [first language].

650 #0 $a [second language].

650 #0 $a [third language].

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

Several languages into one language:

650 #0 $a [topic] $v Dictionaries $x Polyglot.

650 #0 $a Dictionaries, Polyglot.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a [topic].

650 #0 $a [first language].

650 #0 $a [other languages, up to three and optionally more].

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

Several languages into each other language:

650 #0 $a [topic] $v Dictionaries $x Polyglot.

650 #0 $a Dictionaries, Polyglot.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a [topic].

650 #0 $a [first language listed].

650 #0 $a [other languages, up to three and optionally more].

655 ## $a Multilingual dictionaries. $2 lcgft

E.4. Lexicography

For works about dictionaries in a particular subject, establish the topical subdivision ***--Lexicography*** under the subject, for example, ***Science--Lexicography***.

F. Juvenile dictionaries

Use the free-floating form subdivision ***--Dictionaries, Juvenile*** under names of languages or topical headings for dictionaries intended for children up through age 15 or 9th grade.

Do not further subdivide ***--Dictionaries, Juvenile*** by names of languages when used under topical headings. If it is necessary to bring out the language of a juvenile topical dictionary, do so by assigning an additional heading.

For language dictionaries, further divide ***--Dictionaries, Juvenile*** by names of languages, in accordance with the guidelines in sec. D, above, for example, ***French language--Dictionaries, Juvenile--English***.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision. See the LC practice above. Assign the LCDGT appropriate to the audience, e.g. LCDGT ***Children*** and/or ***Teenagers***.

G. Picture dictionaries

Use the heading ***Picture dictionaries, [name of language]*** for general picture dictionaries. If the dictionary is limited to a particular topic, also assign the appropriate heading for subject dictionaries.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision. See the LC practice above. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Picture dictionaries***.

Example:

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650 #0 $a Theater $v Dictionaries.
650 #0 $a Picture dictionaries, English.
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LC practice:

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650 #0 $a Theater.
650 #0 $a English language.
655 ## $a Picture dictionaries. $2 lcgft
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Revision history

2026-03: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.